

remote access and that the ports used by Maintenance Assistant are forwarded properly on your router and firewall. If you don't know what port forwarding is, visit www.portforward.com, and if that doesn't help, bring in your network administrator.

5.3 Action Point of Sale

Another free program to manage inventory is Action Point of Sale. Akin to Maintenance Assistance, this program, too, allows the user to develop a computerised process for saving information related to sales and inventory.

5.3.1 Installation

Installing Action Point of Sale (APOS) is simple. Download it from www.actionpos.co.za or get it from this month's CD. One thing to note here is that, in order to install APOS, you have to be connected to the Internet. The software connects to the Web and activates itself automatically online. Once that's done, the software can be run as many times as you want.

5.3.2 Setting it up

The first time, APOS loads a little slowly, trying to look for inventory information stored in its proprietary format (.refc) on the hard disk. When it cannot find any such information, it opens up a Wizard that allows new users to add backed-up data to the newly-installed program. The Wizard allows you to create an "Inventory Master File" or a "Users Master File", among other options.

The first thing to do when adding inventory is to add suppliers' details. You could do so by clicking on the Suppliers Master File and filling it up using our previous example.



The first time Action Point of Sale is run